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America believes the right approach to a trade deal is to put everything on the table while handling it thoughtfully. A US-India trade deal would take everything into account, not product by product

The US is interested in doing a macro, large-scale, broad-based trade agreement with India. It will require a different kind of thinking...that PM Modi can do, because he has a great relationship with President Trump

India has bought significant amounts of its military hardware from Russia...that needs to end. India is the 'I' in BRICS (which is) trying to create a currency to replace the dollar as the global economic currency. These...don't create the love we deeply feel towards India

If people come into America through the US Gold Card, they will only pay tax in America and not on their global income. It will have quick access to the market, it will be quickly approved, and these great entrepreneurs...will build businesses in the US. (This) will reduce our budget deficit

It is time to do something big, something grand... that connects the US and India on a large scale. Let's bring India's tariffs (on products from) America down, and it will invite India to have an extraordinary relationship

India was a big beneficiary of its ability to trade with America when it had low tariffs while protecting its own market with very high tariffs, he said.

"It's been 80 years since that was set in 1945, but it's time for that to change, and President Trump is thinking about it from the term 'reciprocal'. How you treat us is how we would like to treat you," he added. India has some of the highest tariffs in the world, and that will require a rethinking of the special relationship between India and the United States. He said the US would like to focus on a bilateral conversation to bring down the tariff levels that India has to protect some areas of its economy, like agriculture. Lutnick hoped the US and India would have a comprehensive trade agreement.

On Trump's plans to take back the Panama Canal, Lutnick said America spent a trillion dollars, at today's rates, building the Panama Canal and 38,000 Americans lost their lives to malaria at that time. "Jimmy Carter gave the canal to Panama in exchange for an agreement that says they shall not favour any nation. And what Panama did is that they leased both mouths of the Panama Canal to the Chinese. The Chinese built bridges over the canal, so the US military and all our boats had to go underneath Chinese ports and between Chinese ports," he elaborated.

On Canada, which Trump had threatened to make America's 51st state, Lutnick said that its entire economy leans on America. "It doesn't pay virtually anything into NATO because it just hides behind the United States of America. It knows the United States of America would protect it," he said. He concluded by saying that working for President Trump was the "most favourite" time of his life. ■

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